

Teacher Guide

Heidi · Chapter 1: Going Up to the Alm-Uncle · Grade 3

Lesson Overview

Use this guide to introduce the chapter, support close reading, and prepare students for discussion and writing. This guide is designed for a 60-minute instructional period or two 30-minute sessions.

Measurable Objectives

- Students will be able to Identify and describe the main characters (Heidi, Deta, Grandfather [Alm-Uncle], Peter) using evidence from the text (RL.3.3)
- Students will be able to Define 6 key vocabulary words (avoid, consider, explore, journey, responsible, treasure) using context clues and apply them in sentences (L.3.4)
- Students will be able to Sequence the major events of Heidi's journey up the mountain to Grandfather's hut and explain why each event is important (RL.3.1)
- Students will be able to Make inferences about character feelings and motivations based on their actions and dialogue (RL.3.3)
- Students will be able to Engage effectively in collaborative discussions by building on others' ideas, asking clarifying questions, and providing text evidence to support thinking (SL.3.1)
- Students will be able to Write narratives to develop real or imagined experiences or events using effective technique, descriptive details, and clear event sequences (W.3.3)

Standards

Reading Literature

- **RL.3.1** — Ask and answer questions to demonstrate understanding of a text, referring explicitly to the text as the basis for the answers.
- **RL.3.3** — Describe characters in a story (e.g., their traits, motivations, or feelings) and explain how their actions contribute to the sequence of events.

Writing

- **W.3.3** — Write narratives to develop real or imagined experiences or events using effective technique, descriptive details, and clear event sequences.
- **W.3.4** — With guidance and support from adults, produce writing in which the development and organization are appropriate to task and purpose.

Language

- **L.3.4** — Determine or clarify the meaning of unknown and multiple-meaning word and phrases based on grade 3 reading and content, choosing flexibly from a range of strategies.

Speaking and Listening

- **SL.3.1** — Engage effectively in a range of collaborative discussions (one-on-one, in groups, and teacher-led) with diverse partners on grade 3 topics and texts, building on others' ideas and expressing their own clearly.

Materials Needed

- Heidi, by Johanna Spyri (Classic Books for All edition), Chapter 1, for each student.
- Classic Books for All Heidi Student Workbook.
- Pencil and notebook.
- Whiteboard and markers.
- Optional: Drawing paper and colored pencils.

Get Ready to Read

Quick-write prompt

"Have you ever visited somewhere new and felt excited to look around and discover everything about it?"

Implementation

- Ask students to think about a time they went somewhere new for the first time — a new home, a new school, or a trip somewhere they had never been before.
- Display or read aloud the prompt: 'Think about going to a new place. How did you feel? What did you see or do first?'
- Give students 2–3 quiet minutes to draw or write their ideas.
- Ask students to turn to their neighbor and share what they wrote or drew.
- Tell students that in this chapter, a little girl named Heidi travels up a big mountain to live with her grandfather for the first time — just like they imagined going somewhere new.

Connection tip: Connecting students' own experiences of going somewhere new helps them understand how Heidi might feel as she climbs the mountain to meet her grandfather.

Words to Know Mini-Lesson

Mini-lesson

1. avoid (*page 4*)
2. consider (*page 3*)
3. explore (*page 12*)
4. journey (*page 7*)
5. responsible (*page 5*)
6. treasure (*page 11*)

Activities

Introduce words with context

- Write each word on the board.
- Read the sentence from the book containing the word.
- Think-aloud: "What clues help me understand this word?"
- Example for *explore*: "It was an adventure for her, and she was eager to explore every corner." (p. 12) — Look at the words around it. Heidi is excited and calls it an adventure. The word 'every corner' tells you she wants to go see all the new places around her.

Partner practice

- Assign partners.
- Each pair gets two to three vocabulary words.
- Partners find the word in the text and discuss what it might mean.
- Use sentence: "I think _____ means _____ because the text says _____."

Quick check

- Call on pairs to share definitions.
- Confirm or clarify meanings.
- Post vocabulary words on Word Wall.

Guided Reading with Pause Points

Section 1: pages 1–3

Read from In the cozy little town of Maienfeld, there's a pretty, green path that leads up to the tall mountains. ...

Pause and ask:

1. Who are the two people walking up the mountain path at the start of the chapter?
2. The story says Heidi is wearing several layers of clothes and a big red shawl even though it is summer. What does that tell you about how hot she might feel?
3. The word 'journey' means a trip from one place to another. Find the sentence where Barbara continues her journey. Where is she going on her journey?

Section 2: pages 3–5

Read from Where are you taking the child, Deta? ...

Pause and ask:

1. Why does Deta say she cannot keep taking care of Heidi?
2. Barbara says Alm-Uncle 'doesn't talk to anyone' and 'people avoid him.' The word 'avoid' means to stay away from someone on purpose. Why do you think people in the village avoid Alm-Uncle?
3. Deta looks around to make sure Heidi cannot hear before she tells her story. What does that tell you about what Deta thinks of the story she is about to share?

Section 3: pages 5–8

Read from Hold on, I can't tell you everything at once! ...

Pause and ask:

1. What happened to Tobias and Adelheid that made Alm-Uncle go live alone in the mountains?
2. The story says Tobias was 'very responsible, unlike his father.' The word 'responsible' means doing what you are supposed to do and making good choices. How does the story show that Tobias was responsible?
3. Alm-Uncle lost his farm, his son, and his daughter-in-law. How do you think those sad things might explain why he lives alone on the mountain now?

Section 4: pages 8–10

Read from Suddenly, Heidi sat down and quickly took off her shoes and socks. ...

Pause and ask:

1. What did Heidi take off, and why did she take those things off?
2. Deta offers Peter a five-penny coin and he jumps up right away to go get Heidi's clothes. The story calls the coin a 'treasure' for Peter. What does that tell you about how much money Peter usually has?
3. Heidi watches the goats hop over bushes and stones easily and feels jealous. Then she takes off her heavy clothes and feels just as nimble as the goats. What does this tell you about what kind of child Heidi is?

Section 5: pages 11–13

Read from Good evening, Grandfather! ...

Pause and ask:

1. What does Heidi do when she first meets her grandfather?
2. The story says Grandfather's face softens into a smile when he hears Heidi's voice. Barbara told Deta that Grandfather would not welcome them. Was Barbara right or wrong? Use the text to explain your answer.
3. Grandfather asks what he will do if Heidi cries and misses her family. What does that question tell you about how he feels about taking care of a small child?

Read-aloud tip: After reading each section aloud, invite students to point to the exact sentence in the text that helped them answer the question.

Think About the Story — Answers + Inferential Thinking

What is the name of the little girl being taken up the mountain?

The little girl's name is Heidi, as Deta reveals when she asks, 'Are you tired, Heidi?' (p. 3).

Where is Deta going for her new job?

Deta is going to a beautiful house in Frankfurt. (p. 3).

What does Heidi take off while climbing up the mountain path?

Heidi takes off her shoes, socks, heavy shawl, and two dresses. (p. 8).

Who collects the goats from the village and leads them up the mountain every day?

Peter the goat herder collects the goats from the village and leads them up the mountain every day. (p. 8).

What does Deta offer Peter so he will go back down the hill to fetch Heidi's clothes?

Deta offers Peter a five-penny coin to go back down the hill and fetch Heidi's clothes. (p. 9).

Where is Grandfather's hut located on the mountain?

Grandfather's hut stood at the top of a windy patch of rocky ground where you could see the whole valley. (p. 11).

Inferential Thinking

- Why do you think the villagers call the old man 'Alm-Uncle' even though they are not related to him?
- What does the way Deta talks to Barbara tell us about how Deta feels about leaving Heidi behind?

Tiered Discussion Prompts

Literal: What does Heidi say when Deta asks if she is tired? | How old is Heidi at the start of this chapter?

Inference: Why might Deta look around to make sure Heidi cannot overhear her conversation with Barbara? | What clues suggest that Peter enjoys spending time with the goats more than being at home?

Analysis: How does the author use the description of the mountain path at the beginning of the chapter to set the mood for Heidi's journey? | What does the history of Alm-Uncle's life suggest about why he now lives alone on the mountain?

Evaluation: Do you think Deta made the right choice in bringing Heidi to live with her grandfather? Use details from the chapter to support your answer. | Is it fair that everyone in the village avoids Alm-Uncle based on rumors and gossip? What does this chapter suggest about judging people without knowing the full story?

Analytical Thinking

- How does Johanna Spyri use the conversation between Deta and Barbara to give the reader background information about Alm-Uncle without slowing the story down?
- What details in this chapter suggest that Heidi will adapt well to mountain life, even though the adults around her are worried?

Personal Connection

- Have you ever had to go somewhere new that felt a little scary at first? How did you feel when you arrived?
- Think of a time when you heard something about a person that turned out not to be true. How did meeting that person change what you thought?

Answer Key

Words to Know — Answer Key

Word	Definition	Sentence from book (page)	Example sentence
avoid	to stay away from someone or something on purpose	"People avoid him because he looks and acts so scary." (p. 4)	I avoid puddles on the sidewalk so my shoes don't get wet.
consider	to think carefully about doing something	"You must be out of your mind to consider it." (p. 3)	Before you consider buying that toy, think about whether you really need it.
explore	to look around a new place to see what is there	"It was an adventure for her, and she was eager to explore every corner." (p. 12)	We got to explore the tide pools and found crabs and starfish.
journey	a long trip from one place to another	"Deta said goodbye to Barbara near this hut, and Barbara continued her journey up the mountain." (p. 7)	The family packed snacks for their long journey across the country.
responsible	doing what you are supposed to do and taking care of your duties	"Tobias learned carpentry and was very responsible, unlike his father." (p. 5)	Maria was responsible for feeding the class fish every morning before school.
treasure	something very special or valuable that makes you happy to have	"Peter didn't often get such a treasure." (p. 11)	The birthday card from my grandma felt like a treasure I wanted to keep forever.

Reading Between the Lines — Answers

- **Why might Heidi feel better after taking off her heavy shawl and extra dresses?:** Heidi likely felt better because she had been struggling in the summer heat wearing many layers at once; without the heavy clothes she felt as nimble as the goats and was able to move freely and happily up the mountain. (p. 8)
- **What clues show that Grandfather is not as cold and unfriendly as the villagers believe?:** When Heidi calls out 'Good evening, Grandfather,' the old man's face softens into a smile and he seems pleased to have visitors; this suggests he is capable of warmth even though the villagers describe him as scary and someone to avoid. (p. 11)
- **Why might Peter hesitate before going back down the hill to get Heidi's clothes?:** Peter says he is already late, and he stands frozen with his hands in his pockets, suggesting he is both afraid of Deta's anger and reluctant to do extra work on top of his long day herding goats. (p. 9)

Dig Deeper — Answers

- **How does the way the villagers talk about Alm-Uncle compare to the way he actually behaves when Heidi arrives at his hut?:** The villagers describe Alm-Uncle as scary, spooky, and someone everyone avoids, but when Heidi arrives he looks up at her voice, his face softens into a smile, and he holds her hand and looks at her carefully; this contrast suggests that rumors and gossip have given the villagers a much harsher picture of him than the truth. (p. 4)
- **What does Heidi's decision to remove her heavy clothes and join Peter and the goats reveal about her character?:** Heidi's quick, practical decision to shed her extra layers and run freely with Peter and the goats shows that she is independent, resourceful, and unafraid of doing things her own way, even when an adult like Deta might not approve. (p. 8)

- **What does this chapter suggest about why Deta feels it is right to leave Heidi with her grandfather, even though Barbara thinks it is a terrible idea?:** Deta argues that she has already cared for Heidi for four years on her own, without anyone's help, and that the grandfather has a responsibility to do his part; this suggests Deta believes family duty matters and that she has already given more than her share, even if her decision still makes her uncomfortable. (p. 12)

Multiple Choice — Answers

- **Why does Deta say she cannot keep looking after Heidi?:** A — Deta clearly states that she has been offered a job in Frankfurt and cannot take Heidi with her. Option B is wrong because Deta is leaving the village, not returning to it. Option C is wrong because Grandfather never asked for Heidi. Option D is a detail that is mentioned but is not the reason Deta gives for leaving Heidi with Grandfather.
- **What does Peter do after Deta holds a five-penny coin under his nose?:** C — The text states that the coin made Peter jump and he hurried down the straightest path and returned in a short time. Options A, B, and D are not supported by the text.
- **What does Grandfather do when he first hears Heidi call out to him?:** B — The text says 'The old man looked up at the sound of her voice, his face softening into a smile.' Options A, C, and D contradict what is described in the chapter.

Evidence from the Story — Sample Answers

- **Find and write the words that show how Heidi felt about being at her grandfather's hut high in the mountains.:** Heidi was thrilled and eager to explore everything around her. The text says she was excited and that her grandfather felt joy in her excitement. *It was an adventure for her, and she was eager to explore every corner.* (p. 12)
- **Find and write the words that show what the villagers think of Alm-Uncle and why they stay away from him.:** The villagers think Alm-Uncle is scary and spooky, so they avoid him. Barbara says he has big grey eyebrows, a long beard, and a twisted walking stick. *People avoid him because he looks and acts so scary.* (p. 4)
- **Find and write the words that show how Heidi looked and acted after she took off her heavy layers of clothing.:** After removing her extra clothes, Heidi felt light and free, just like the goats on the mountain. *She now felt as nimble as the goats themselves.* (p. 9)

Character Chart — Answer Key

Character	Description	What This Shows	Quote	Page
Heidi	A five-year-old girl with rosy cheeks who is being taken up the mountain to live with her grandfather.	Heidi is curious, independent, and quick to adapt; she removes her heavy clothes without hesitation and cheerfully greets her grandfather.	Good evening, Grandfather!	11
Deta	Heidi's aunt and caregiver who is bringing Heidi to live with Alm-Uncle so she can take a job in Frankfurt.	Deta is practical and determined; she has cared for Heidi on her own and believes the grandfather must now take his share of responsibility.	He has to do his part for Heidi now.	4
Alm-Uncle (Grandfather)	An old man who lives alone at the top of the mountain and is feared by the villagers because of his	Despite the rumors, Grandfather shows warmth when Heidi arrives, suggesting there is more to him than the villagers believe.	The old man looked up at the sound of her voice, his face softening into a smile.	11

Character	Description	What This Shows	Quote	Page
	scary appearance and unfriendly reputation.			
Peter	An eleven-year-old goat herder who leads the village goats up the mountain every day and lives with his mother and blind grandmother.	Peter is hardworking and practical, spending most of his day alone with the goats; he is also motivated by small rewards like the five-penny coin.	Peter didn't often get such a treasure.	11
Barbara	A friendly woman from the village who joins Deta on the mountain path and asks questions about Alm-Uncle's past.	Barbara represents the curious and gossipy attitude of the villagers; she wants to know the truth about Alm-Uncle but is also nervous about him.	I'm glad it's not me going to live with the old man.	4

Draw It! — Suggested Details

- Heidi standing on the steep mountain path with a pile of dresses, shoes, and a red shawl next to her feet
- Peter walking ahead with his goats hopping over rocks and bushes
- Grandfather sitting on his wooden bench outside his hut, holding his pipe and looking down at the valley
- Three tall fir trees rising up behind Grandfather's hut with a rocky cliff face in the background
- Deta holding out a five-penny coin toward Peter on the mountainside

Bonus Challenge — Answer Key (Correct Order)

1. Deta and Heidi climb the mountain path from Maienfeld, stopping when Barbara comes out of her cottage to join them.
2. Heidi wanders away from Deta and Barbara and begins climbing the mountainside with Peter and his goats.
3. Heidi takes off her shoes, socks, shawl, and extra dresses and leaves them in a pile on the hillside.
4. Deta gives Peter a five-penny coin to run back down and fetch Heidi's clothes. "Peter didn't often get such a treasure."
5. Deta said goodbye to Barbara near this hut, and Barbara continued her journey up the mountain.
6. Heidi, Peter, and Deta arrive at Grandfather's hut, and Heidi calls out, "Good evening, Grandfather!"
7. Deta tells Grandfather, "I've taken care of Heidi for the last four years. Now it's your turn to look after her," and it was an adventure for Heidi, and she was eager to explore every corner.

Differentiated Supports

Struggling Readers

Before reading: Show students a simple drawing or map of a mountain path with a village partway up and a hut at the top. Point to where Deta, Heidi, and Grandfather are and explain that this is where the story takes place. | Pre-teach the six vocabulary words using picture cards. For each word, say the word, show a simple picture, and use it in a sentence about something familiar to students. | Tell students in one or two sentences what happens in the chapter: 'A girl named Heidi is brought up a big mountain to live with her grandfather. She has never met him before.'

During reading: Read the chapter aloud together in short sections of one or two pages at a time. After each section, pause and ask one literal question such as 'Why is Heidi wearing so many clothes?' or 'What does Heidi say when she meets Grandfather?' | Give students a simple story map with four boxes labeled: Who, Where, What Happens First, and What Happens at the End. Help them fill it in as you read. | When students reach a word from the vocabulary list, stop and read the definition together before continuing.

After reading: Ask students to draw one scene from the chapter and write one sentence about it using the sentence starter: 'In this picture, Heidi is ____.' | Ask two or three literal questions students can answer by pointing to a sentence in the text, such as 'What does Heidi take off on the mountain path?' and 'Where does Grandfather sit outside his hut?' | Have students retell what happened using three picture cards you provide: Heidi climbing the path, Heidi taking off her clothes, and Heidi meeting Grandfather.

English Language Learners

Before reading: Show students pictures of a mountain, a goat, a hut, a shawl, and a bench. Say each word clearly and have students repeat it. Explain that these things will appear in the story. | Pre-teach the six vocabulary words using simple definitions, a picture, and a gesture for each word. For example, for 'avoid,' cross your arms and step away to show staying away from something. | Give a brief oral summary of the chapter in simple sentences: 'A woman named Deta takes a little girl named Heidi up a mountain. Heidi will live with her grandfather. His name is Alm-Uncle. He lives alone.'

During reading: Pair students with a reading partner. Partners take turns reading one paragraph at a time and stop to check that both understand what happened. | Provide a bilingual glossary card with the six vocabulary words and their definitions written in simple English. Encourage students to check the card whenever they see one of the words. | After reading each page, ask students to point to one thing they learned about Heidi and one thing they learned about Grandfather.

After reading: Have students complete sentence frames to show understanding: 'Deta is taking Heidi to ____.' 'Grandfather lives ____.' 'Heidi takes off her clothes because ____.' | Ask students to draw Heidi at the beginning of the chapter and at the end of the chapter. Have them label at least two things in each drawing. | In pairs, have students practice retelling the chapter to each other using the question prompts: Who is in the story? Where do they go? What happens when they get there?

Advanced Students

Before reading: Ask students to predict what it might be like to suddenly go live with a family member you have never met. Have them write two or three sentences about how they would feel and why. | Challenge students to think about why the author begins the story with a description of the mountain path and the weather. Ask: 'Why might an author start a story by describing a place?' | Have students look up the word 'gossip' and think about how gossip about Alm-Uncle might make Heidi's arrival harder or easier.

During reading: As students read, ask them to track how different characters feel about Heidi going to live with Grandfather. Have them use a simple two-column chart with the headings 'Thinks it is a good idea' and 'Thinks it is a bad idea' and add character names as they read. | Ask students to pay attention to how Alm-Uncle is described before Heidi meets him and then notice how he acts when she arrives. Have them write a question mark next to any moment that surprises them. | Challenge students to notice clues in the text that tell us about Heidi's personality. Ask: 'What does Heidi do and say that shows what kind of person she is?'

After reading: Have students write a short journal entry from Heidi's point of view at the end of the chapter. They should describe what she sees, how she feels about meeting Grandfather, and what she is wondering about her new life. | Ask students to compare how Barbara and Deta feel about Grandfather. Have them write two or three sentences explaining which character they agree with more and why, using details from the text. | Challenge students to think about whether Deta made a fair choice in leaving Heidi with Grandfather. Ask them to write one sentence that supports Deta's choice and one sentence that argues against it, using evidence from the chapter.

Common Student Questions

1. Why is Heidi wearing so many clothes if it is hot outside? (p. 8)

Deta did not want to carry extra clothes in her pack, so she dressed Heidi in her Sunday clothes on top of her everyday clothes to bring them up the mountain.

2. Why does Heidi take off her clothes and shoes on the path? (p. 8)

Heidi was very hot and found the heavy clothes hard to walk in. She took them off so she could move more easily, like Peter and the goats.

3. Why is Deta leaving Heidi with her grandfather? (p. 3)

Deta got a new job far away in Frankfurt and cannot take Heidi with her. She believes the grandfather should help take care of his own granddaughter.

4. Why does everyone call the old man 'Alm-Uncle' if he is not really their uncle? (p. 5)

People in the village started calling him 'Uncle' long ago, and the name stuck. When he moved to the mountain farm called the Alm, they added that word too.

5. Why does Grandfather live alone on the mountain and not talk to anyone? (p. 7)

After his son Tobias and Adelheid both died, Grandfather became very sad and stopped speaking with people. He moved up the mountain to be by himself.

6. Why does Peter run down the hill to get Heidi's clothes after standing still at first? (p. 9)

Peter did not want to go because he was already late with the goats. He only went when Deta offered him a five-penny coin as a reward.

7. Why does Grandfather seem upset when Deta brings Heidi to him? (p. 12)

Grandfather was not expecting Heidi and did not know how to care for a small child. He was worried she would cry and miss Deta.

Creative Response

Common errors

No Specific Details From The Chapter

Sometimes students write about Heidi in a very general way, without using any details from the chapter. Strong creative responses use specific things from the story, like Heidi taking off her heavy boots and extra dresses on the mountain path, or Heidi calling out 'Good evening, Grandfather!' when she reached the hut.

Weak example: Heidi walked up the mountain and met her grandfather. She was happy.

How to fix: Ask students to look back at the chapter and find one or two small details — something Heidi did, said, or saw — and put those details into their writing.

Breaking Character

Students sometimes make Heidi act in ways that do not match who she is in the chapter. In the story, Heidi is curious, cheerful, and brave. She happily climbs the steep mountain, talks to Peter about the goats, and greets her grandfather with a big smile. If a student writes Heidi as shy, scared, or mean, that does not match the character in the text.

Weak example: Heidi was too scared to talk to her grandfather. She hid behind Deta and cried.

How to fix: Remind students to check the chapter. Ask: 'Does Heidi act scared in the story? What does she actually do and say?' Then have them rewrite so Heidi acts the way she does in the book.

Retelling The Whole Chapter Instead of Focusing on Heidi's Experience

Some students simply copy what already happened in the chapter instead of creating something new. The creative prompt asks students to imagine and write, not just repeat the story back. For example, retelling that Deta walked Heidi up the mountain and talked to Barbara is not a creative response — it is just a summary.

Weak example: Heidi walked up the mountain with Deta. Deta talked to Barbara. Then Heidi took off her clothes and Peter got them.

How to fix: Remind students that a creative response means they add something new — a thought Heidi might have, a question she might ask her grandfather, or how she feels looking down at the valley. It should not just list things that already happened.

No Evidence From the Text

Students sometimes write things about Heidi or her grandfather that are not supported by anything in the chapter. For example, the chapter shows that the grandfather looks gruff but his face softens when he sees Heidi — students should not write that he was cruel or that he turned them away, because that is not what the text shows.

Weak example: Grandfather was mean and slammed the door. He told Heidi to go away forever.

How to fix: Have students find one sentence in the chapter that supports what they want to write. If they cannot find a sentence, they should change their idea to match what the story actually shows.

Modern Language That Doesn't Fit The Story

Students may use very modern words or phrases that do not fit the world of the story. Heidi lives in an old mountain village long ago. She would not say things like 'Okay, cool!' or 'No problem!' or talk about things from today's world. The language in the creative response should feel simple and old-fashioned, like the book itself.

Weak example: Heidi said, 'Wow, Grandfather, this place is awesome! Can we hang out here all day?'

How to fix: Read a few lines from the chapter aloud with students. Point out how the characters speak — short, plain sentences. Then ask students to rewrite their dialogue to sound more like the characters in the book.

Exit Ticket

Prompt: Predict what will happen next chapter, and explain why using a detail from the text.

Success Criteria

- Makes a clear prediction about what will happen next
- Uses a detail from the chapter as text evidence
- Explains the thinking using the word because

Example Responses

Strong: I predict that Grandfather will be grumpy when Deta leaves Heidi with him because in the chapter he said he would not know what to do if Heidi started crying. I think Heidi and Grandfather will have a hard time at first getting used to each other.

Developing: I think Deta will leave and Grandfather will be mad. He did not want Heidi to come.